

Cover

Foreword

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About Me

I found Chhau two years ago. I was preparing for an international dance competition and looking for a form I hadn't worked with before, and my mentor, who was trained in Mayurbhanj Chhau, opened my eyes to the world of Chhau. I only meant to learn enough for one performance, but it pulled me in further than I expected. Every day in school while the team practiced for different compositions, we would find ourselves doing Chhau for fun, wanting more.

What surprised me was how hard it was to find reliable and satisfactory information about it. I'd look things up and keep hitting dead ends, or scattered pages that didn't add up to a full picture. It seemed wrong that something this old and this important was so hard to actually learn about.

I'm an actor and a dancer, and am a student in the IB Diploma Programme. I'm not an expert on Chhau. But I spent a long time trying to understand it, and I wanted to put all of what I found over two years in a single place so the next person doesn't have to start from nothing, so that I might make an effort to preserve it.

That's all this eBook really is — a clear, honest and structured introduction to Chhau for anyone, especially younger people, who want to learn about it and contribute to its preservation.

Arnav Ajana

About Chhau

Chhau is one of India's oldest and most physically demanding dance forms. It grew out of martial training and slowly became a performance art, and this eBook tries to cover that whole story — where it came from and what it has become.

Chhau, much like Hip-Hop, consists of more than a single dance style. There are three main regional forms, and they're quite different from each other. Seraikella Chhau tells its stories through masks. Purulia Chhau is fast and acrobatic in its nature. Mayurbhanj Chhau is performed without masks and relies on the body alone. What ties them together is the music — the dhol, dhamsa, and shehnai that aim to create the same environment in every performance.

I wanted this resource to reflect how alive the dance is, so it includes video demonstrations, breakdowns of the actual movements, and the history behind them. It also looks at how Chhau tells its stories, the role of costume and colour, and the training that keeps these traditions going inside the communities that practice them.

I owe a lot to the artists who took the time to share what they know. Their dedication is what convinced me that Chhau, however old it is, still has a place in our world.

As you read on, try not to stop at the terminologies and the 3D Sandboxes. Practice those movements and aim to understand the essence.

How to Use this Interactive eBook

Map of Chhau: Families, Epicenters

First Look at Chhau Video

The World Of Chhau

What is Chhau

Origins, Etymology and Historical Layers

The Chhau Body

Movement Vocabulary and Formations

Storytelling; Archetypes

Expressions

Music, Rhythm and Instruments

Costumes and Colour

Props

Performance Space, Training and Community

Section: Mayurbhanj

Entering Mayurbhanj Chhau

Patrons

Traditions

Movement Techniques

Evolution and Pioneers

Performance

Section: Seraikella

Entering Seraikella Chhau

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Section: Purulia

Entering Purulia Chhau

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Glossary, Index and Library

